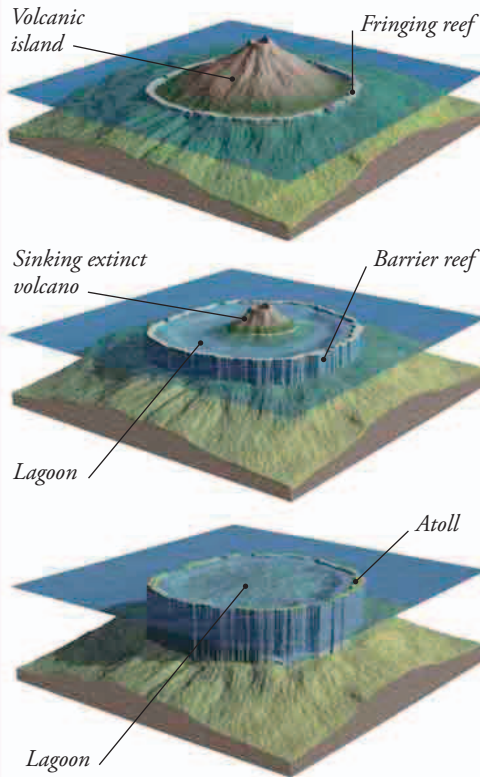


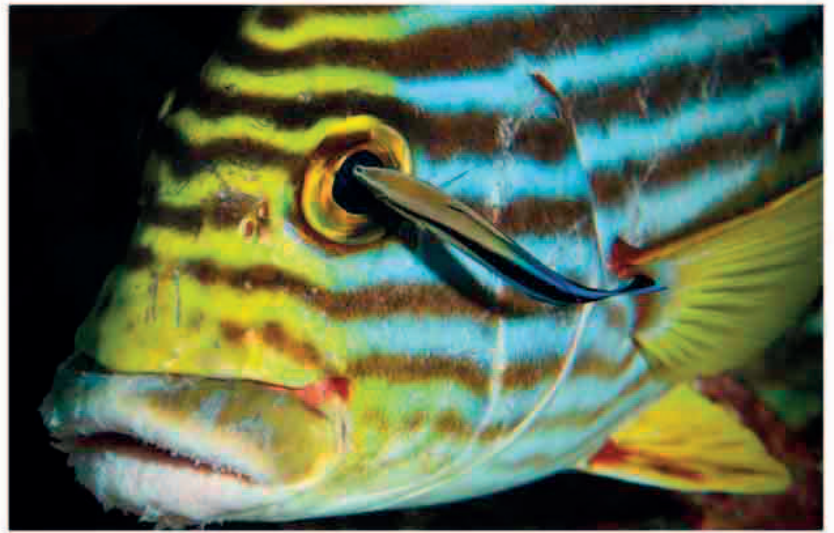
CORAL ATOLLS

The tropical Pacific is dotted with extinct volcanic islands that are sinking into the ocean floor. The islands are fringed with coral reefs that grow upward as the islands sink. Gradually, fringing reefs turn into barrier reefs around the dwindling central islands. Eventually, the islands vanish, leaving coral atolls around shallow lagoons.



CORAL ISLANDS

The circular reefs known as atolls enclose shallow, sheltered lagoons, and are often topped by islands of white coral sand. The islands, and the trees that grow on them, are breeding sites for sea turtles and ocean birds such as these frigate birds.



DAZZLING DIVERSITY

Coral reefs support an amazing diversity of sea life. This is because food is quite scarce, so reef animals have had to evolve unusual ways to survive, creating many species. One of the most intriguing is the bluestreak cleaner wrasse, which feeds on parasites that it picks off the skin of larger fish. It is so popular with its clients that they line up for treatment.

▲ VALET SERVICE
A cleaner wrasse wipes the eyes of an oriental sweetlips.

STARFISH PLAGUES

Coral reefs in the Indian and Pacific Oceans are often attacked by coral-eating crown-of-thorns starfish. These envelop the living coral and digest it, leaving just the stony reef skeletons. A big swarm of these spiny starfish can completely wreck a reef, but then the starfish run out of food and die off, allowing the reef to recover.

► CORAL KILLER

The crown-of-thorns has sharp, venomous spines.

